

Magellan Scholar Grant

Comprehensive Applicant & Mentor Guide

University of South Carolina
Office of Undergraduate Research

Academic Year 2025–2026

Compiled by J.C. Vaught

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This document is an unofficial compilation of publicly available information from the USC Office of Undergraduate Research. Always consult the official [Magellan Scholar Guidebook](#) and [OUR website](#) for the most current requirements.

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Program Overview

The **Magellan Scholar Award** is a competitive research grant administered by the University of South Carolina's [Office of Undergraduate Research \(OUR\)](#). Established in 2005, the program has funded over 1,000 undergraduate research, scholarly, and creative projects across every discipline—from science, technology, and engineering to theatre, music, and art.

Key Facts at a Glance

Award Amount	Up to \$2,500 per student
Eligibility	Undergraduate, degree-seeking students at <i>any</i> USC system campus
GPA Requirement	Minimum institutional GPA of 3.200
Disciplines	All disciplines (STEM, social sciences, humanities, arts, business)
Grant Type	Research grant (NOT a scholarship; does not affect financial aid)
Use of Funds	Salary, materials/supplies, research travel
Mentor	Faculty, staff, or community mentor required
Award Duration	Approximately 12 months

Important: The Magellan Scholar Grant is only available to **undergraduate** students. Graduate students are not eligible. For graduate research funding, see the [SPARC Graduate Research Grant](#) (\$5,000, PhD/MFA/MA Public History only).

Discipline Distribution

Historically, about **50%** of awards go to science and engineering students, **25%** to social science students, and **25%** to students in the humanities, arts, and business.

Campus Eligibility

The Magellan Scholar Grant is open to students on **all USC system campuses**:

- USC Columbia
- USC Aiken
- USC Beaufort
- USC Upstate
- USC Lancaster (Palmetto College)
- USC Salkehatchie (Palmetto College)
- USC Sumter (Palmetto College)
- USC Union (Palmetto College)

Note: Different campuses may have different submission deadlines. In Fall 2024, Hurricane Helene caused extended deadlines for some campuses. Always verify campus-specific deadlines with OUR.

Eligibility Requirements

Student Eligibility

1. Must be a **USC degree-seeking undergraduate student** (any campus, any discipline, any academic year).

2. Minimum institutional **GPA of 3.200**.
3. Must have an identified **faculty mentor** willing to collaborate on the project.
4. Must complete the **Application Workshop Video** (required once; if completed in a prior semester, does not need to be repeated).

Who Cannot Apply

- Graduate students (Master’s, PhD, professional degree students).
- Non-degree-seeking or visiting students.
- Students below a 3.200 institutional GPA.

Repeat Applicants

Students may **resubmit proposals** that were not funded in a previous cycle. However:

- You must follow the **current semester’s guidebook**, forms, and formatting—do not reuse old forms.
- Pay special attention to the **resubmission section** in the guidebook.
- Changes occur each application round; it is your responsibility to follow the latest requirements.

Deadlines & Timeline (2025–2026)

Cycle	Deadline	Announcement	Grant Period
Fall 2025	Oct 8, 2025 by 5:00 PM	By Dec 15, 2025	~Dec 2025 – Nov 2026
Spring 2026	Feb 11, 2026 by 5:00 PM	By Apr 17, 2026	~Apr 2026 – Mar 2027

Important: For the 2025–2026 academic year, a **large number of applications** is anticipated. This will likely result in a **lower percentage of funded applications** compared to previous years. Plan accordingly and submit your strongest possible proposal.

Special Deadlines

- **College of Nursing** and **Arnold School of Public Health** have modified submission procedures and earlier internal deadlines. Contact your respective college coordinator for details.
- **USCeRA approval routing** should be complete at least **3 business days** before the OUR deadline (allows 2 business days for unit head and dean review).

Application Process Step-by-Step

Step 1: Read the Guidebook

The [Magellan Scholar Guidebook](#) is the definitive resource. Read it thoroughly before beginning your proposal. It covers eligibility, formatting, proposal content, forms, and compliance requirements.

Step 2: Identify a Faculty Mentor

Your mentor must be a USC faculty or staff member (or approved community mentor). The mentor will:

- Collaborate on proposal development.
- Submit the application through USCeRA.
- Complete the Mentor Collaboration Form.
- Authorize all expenditures during the award period.

Step 3: Watch the Application Workshop Video

Required for first-time applicants. If you watched it in a previous semester, you do not need to repeat it.

Step 4: Develop Your Proposal

Write a competitive research, scholarly, or creative project proposal in collaboration with your faculty mentor. The key to a successful application is **how well you describe your project plan**.

Step 5: Prepare Budget

Develop a detailed budget using the current semester's budget form. The maximum request is \$2,500. Funds can cover:

- Student salary/stipend
- Materials and supplies (generally $\leq 10\%$ of total budget)
- Research travel (domestic or international)

Step 6: Assemble Application Documents

Combine into **ONE Word or PDF document**:

- Project description / proposal
- Budget form and justification
- Primary Faculty Collaboration Form (mentor completes this)
- Secondary Mentor Form(s), if applicable
- Non-USC Co-Mentor Letter, if applicable

Group Proposals: Name the file StudentLastName1_StudentLastName2. The USCeRA title should follow the format: Magellan-StudentLastName1_StudentLastName2-ProjectTitle.

Step 7: Submit via USCeRA

The mentor submits the full application through the [USCeRA system](#). Steps:

1. Log into USCeRA.
2. Complete the Proposal/Award Processing (PAP) form.
3. Upload all proposal components.
4. Complete supplemental web-based forms as prompted.
5. Route the proposal via the “Start Approval Process” button.

6. Proposal routes: Chair → Dean → SAM for approval.

USCeRA Resources

- [Magellan Scholar USCeRA Submission Guide](#)
- [USCeRA User Guide](#)
- Technical support: Debbie Kassianos, kassiano@sc.edu, 803-777-6421

Proposal Writing Guide

Proposal Structure

While specific sections vary by discipline, a strong Magellan Scholar proposal typically includes:

1. **Introduction / Background** — Context, literature review, and rationale for the project.
2. **Research Question / Creative Objective** — Clear statement of what you aim to investigate or create.
3. **Significance** — Why does this project matter? What contribution does it make?
4. **Methodology / Project Plan** — Detailed description of your approach, methods, techniques.
5. **Timeline** — Realistic schedule for completing the project within the grant period.
6. **Expected Outcomes** — What you expect to find, produce, or learn.
7. **Budget Justification** — Explanation of how requested funds will be used.
8. **References / Bibliography** — Cited works supporting your proposal.

Review Rubric

Proposals are evaluated by reviewers using a formal rubric. The publicly available rubric (Fall 2019 revision) assesses:

Criterion	Description	Max Points
Writing Style	Clear, persuasive, logical; well organized with few errors	32
Project Description	Quality of research question, methodology, timeline	Varies
Significance	Contribution to the field or discipline	Varies
Feasibility	Can the project realistically be completed?	Varies
Mentor Collaboration	Quality of mentor–student plan	Varies

Full rubric: [mgs_review_rubric.pdf](#)

Tips for a Strong Proposal

1. **Start early.** Set up a timeline so your mentor can review multiple drafts.
2. **Be specific.** Vague methodology is the most common weakness.
3. **Write clearly.** Reviewers come from many disciplines; avoid excessive jargon.
4. **Justify your budget.** Every line item should connect to a project activity.
5. **Show significance.** Explain why your project matters beyond your own interest.
6. **Use the rubric.** Score your own proposal against the review criteria before submitting.
7. **Proofread.** Grammatical errors and typos undermine credibility.

Budget Guidelines

Maximum Award

\$2,500 per student. You do not have to request the full amount. Group proposals receive up to \$2,500 per student (e.g., a group of 3 could receive up to \$7,500 total).

Allowable Expenses

- **Student salary / stipend**
- **Materials and supplies** (generally $\leq 10\%$ of total)
- **Research travel** (domestic or international; must comply with USC travel policies)

Prohibited Expenses

- Mentor compensation (salary, benefits, or travel)
- Graduate student compensation (salary, benefits, or travel)
- Other faculty expenses
- Tuition for study abroad programs (room/board *may* be covered)
- Conference travel (use the [Magellan Voyager Award](#) instead)

How Funds Are Managed

- Awards are transferred by the Controller's Office into internal fund "N" accounts in the mentor's department.
- Setup occurs approximately 3–4 weeks after award announcement.
- The **mentor authorizes all expenditures**.
- The department business manager processes transactions.
- Funds may only be used for the specific awarded student(s) and project.

Group Projects

Group proposals are permitted under these rules:

- Maximum of **3 students per mentor** (one group proposal, or one group plus one individual).
- A mentor may not be PI/co-PI on more than **2 applications per round**.
- Mentors with a currently funded group project through Magellan **may not submit another group proposal**.
- Group participation must be **justified** in both the methods section and the mentor collaboration form.
- Each student in a group receives up to \$2,500.

Post-Award Requirements

Once awarded, Magellan Scholars must fulfill the following:

CITI Training

Complete the **CITI Responsible Conduct of Research (RCR)** online training. Access through the [CITI Program website](#). Two module tracks:

- **Social & Behavioral Research** — for social/behavioral projects.
- **Biomedical** — for biomedical projects.

CITI Training Resources

- [CITI Training How-To Guide \(USC OUR\)](#)
- [CITI Registration FAQ](#)
- Contact: Office of Research Compliance, 803-576-7276

Project Registration

Register your project at the **beginning of each semester** of involvement, and re-register every semester throughout the grant period.

Compliance

Human Subjects (IRB)

- Undergraduate Magellan research is typically *not* required to undergo formal IRB review.
- However, students involved in a mentor's IRB-approved project must be added to the existing protocol.
- CITI Human Subjects training is recommended for all projects involving people (interviews, surveys, personal information).
- Contact: IRB Coordinator, Newtonla@mailbox.sc.edu, 803-576-7276.

Animal Subjects (IACUC)

- IACUC approval is **not** required before proposal submission.
- Students **may not begin** animal research until IACUC approval is obtained.
- The proposal must include a statement that the mentor is submitting for Animal Use approval.
- Contact: Dept. of Animal Resources, iacuc@mailbox.sc.edu, 803-777-8106.

International Research / Travel Abroad

- All international travel must comply with USC policies **and** the [Education Abroad Office](#).
- Students must register with the Education Abroad Office.
- USC-sponsored travel health insurance is **required**.
- All travel must be completed **before graduation**.
- Magellan funds will **not** pay for study abroad tuition (room/board may be covered).
- Contact: edabroad@sc.edu, 803-777-7557.

No Extensions

Extensions past the stated end date or after the student graduates are **not permitted**.

For Faculty Mentors / PIs

Mentor Responsibilities

1. Collaborate with the student on proposal development.

2. Complete the **Mentor Collaboration Form** detailing your role and expertise.
3. Submit the full application via **USCeRA**.
4. **Authorize all expenditures** throughout the award.
5. Ensure ethical standards and regulatory compliance.
6. Review and approve final reports before submission.
7. Oversee student training and skill development.

Mentor Limits

- No more than **2 applications per round** as PI/co-PI.
- Maximum of **3 students** (one group or one group + one individual).
- Cannot submit a new group proposal if a group project is currently funded.

Sabbatical / Extended Leave

Mentors anticipating sabbaticals or extended leave during the project period must:

- Identify a **secondary faculty mentor** to supervise during the absence.
- Alternatively, consider delaying the proposal until after return from leave.

Non-USC Co-Mentors

Non-USC co-mentors may provide a **letter of support** in lieu of the standard mentor collaboration form.

Examples of Funded Projects

The following are publicly documented examples of Magellan Scholar projects across disciplines, illustrating the breadth of the program.

Biological Sciences

Student	Project Title	Mentor
Anna Bazell	Functional Analysis of STN1 Winged Helix Domains	Dr. Jason Stewart
William Caspino	Germination Success Following Chronic Radiation Exposure	Dr. Tim Mousseau
Dylan Davis	Plasticity of Mixotrophy: Molecular and Ecological Responses in <i>Cryptomonas ovata</i>	Dr. Jeff Dudycha
Kaitlyn Dirr	Seasonal Use of Gopher Tortoise Burrows in Coastal Beach Dunes	Dr. Josh Stone
Kirsten Fisher	Perception of Green Leaf Volatiles by Plant Cells	Dr. Johannes Strattmann
Megan Glover	Effects of High-Fat Diets on Adipose Tissue and Immune Function	Dr. Alissa Armstrong

Student	Project Title	Mentor
Benjamin Hurley	DNA Barcoding to Assess Dietary Composition of Highly Migratory Species in the Northwest Atlantic	Dr. Joe Quattro
Catherine Alexander	Quantifying Urban Artificial Light on Pollination Success of <i>Glandularia bipinnatifida</i>	(Faculty mentor)

Psychology & Behavioral Sciences

Student	Project Title	Year
Ella Ahrens	Premature Language Decline in Women with the FMR1 Premutation	—
Sydney Burrell	Mother-Child Synchrony as a Predictor of Problem Behavior and Autism-Related Deficits in Individuals with Fragile X Syndrome	—

Education

Students	Project Title	Campus
Adam Taylor Eubanks, Deanna McCord, Skyla Watson	Examining the Perceived Self-Efficacy of Inclusive Special Area Teachers in K-12 Classrooms	USC Aiken

Note: This was a group proposal; the three students received a combined \$7,500.

History & Humanities

Student	Project Title	Details
Monica Bowman	Richard Howell Gleaves: Reconstruction-Era Politician in South Carolina	1,000th Magellan Scholar; mentored by Dr. Melissa Cooper

International Business

Student	Project Details	Mentor
Joy Gannaway	Immersive study in Mauritius (international business research)	Prof. Lite Nartey

Medical / Public Health

Dr. Anna Hoppmann, now a pediatric oncologist, received a Magellan Scholar award as an anthropology major to conduct community-based participatory research on the need for medical interpretation in clinical settings—an example of how Magellan research shapes long-term careers.

Broader Discipline Coverage

Past Magellan Scholar projects have spanned: opera direction, environmental health, marine biology, Czech history, community health outreach, chemical engineering, electrical engineering, computing, and biomedical engineering, among many others.

Related USC Funding Opportunities

Undergraduate Research Mini-Grant

Amount	Up to \$1,000 per student
Disciplines	All
Use	Salary, materials, research travel (NOT conference travel)
Fall 2025 Deadline	October 21, 2025, 5:00 PM
Spring 2026 Deadline	March 24, 2026, 5:00 PM
GPA Requirement	Not specified (lower barrier than Magellan Scholar)

Magellan Voyager Award

Amount	Up to \$500
Purpose	Travel to conferences to present research
Note	Research does NOT need to be OUR-sponsored

Conference Presentation Grant

Up to \$500 for travel to conferences, symposiums, and meetings to present posters, give talks, or perform.

SPARC Graduate Research Grant (Graduate Only)

Amount	Up to \$5,000
Eligibility	PhD (2nd year+), MFA, MA Public History only
Website	go.sc.edu/SPARC

NSF REU Programs at USC

Program			Focus	Details
Physics & Astronomy REU			Nuclear/particle physics, nanotech, modeling	10 weeks, 8 participants
Criminal (DCJS)	Justice	REU	Race, class, gender in CJ system	10 weeks, 9 participants

Program	Focus	Details
Chemical Engineering REU	Nanostructured materials for energy	Summer
Quantum Information Science REU	Quantum computing	Summer
Mathematics REU	Mathematical Foundations of Data Analysis	NSF RTG funded

Funding Strategy Summary

Tier	Amount	Programs
1 — Primary	\$2,500	Magellan Scholar Grant
2 — Supplemental	\$1,000	Undergraduate Research Mini-Grant
3 — Travel	\$500	Magellan Voyager Award; Conference Presentation Grant
4 — Summer	Varies	NSF REU Programs (typically \$5,000+ with stipend)

These can be combined—e.g., a Magellan Scholar could also apply for a Voyager Award to present findings at a conference.

Research Presentation Opportunities

Discover USC

System-wide showcase of student research, scholarship, and leadership. Multiple presentation formats available. Open to all USC campuses.

Discovery Day Abstracts

Historical abstracts (2004–2014) are archived on [Scholar Commons](#). Browse by discipline or author to see past project examples.

Summer Research Symposium

Poster presentation event for summer research projects across all disciplines.

Carolina CrossTalk

Student-run publication documenting “the personal story behind research projects.”

Regional Campus Events

- **USC Aiken** — Scholar Showcase (mid-April)
- **USC Beaufort** — Student Research and Scholarship Day (mid-to-late April)
- **USC Upstate** — Research Symposium (late March to early April)

Important: Before sharing research publicly, verify with your mentor whether your work has commercialization potential. It may fall under intellectual property protections and require clearance.

Key Contacts

Office / Contact	Role	Email / Phone
Office of Undergraduate Research	General support, applications	our@sc.edu , 803-777-1141
Debbie Kassianos (SAM)	USCeRA technical support	Legare College, Suite 120 kassiano@sc.edu , 803-777-6421
Office of Research Compliance IRB Coordinator	CITI training, IRB Human subjects	803-576-7276 Newtonla@mailbox.sc.edu
Dept. of Animal Resources	IACUC / animal subjects	iacuc@mailbox.sc.edu , 803-777-8106
Education Abroad Office	International travel compliance	edabroad@sc.edu , 803-777-7557
USC Financial & Business Svcs	N-account fund transfers	803-821-1900

Frequently Asked Questions

Is the Magellan Scholar Grant a scholarship?

No. It is a research grant. It does **not** impact your financial aid.

Can graduate students apply?

No. The Magellan Scholar Grant is exclusively for undergraduate students.

Can I apply from any USC campus?

Yes. All USC system campuses are eligible. Deadlines may vary by campus.

Can I reapply if my proposal was not funded?

Yes. Follow the current semester's guidebook and forms. Do not reuse old forms.

Do I have to request the full \$2,500?

No. Request only what your project needs.

Can I do a group project?

Yes. Up to 3 students per mentor. Group participation must be justified in the proposal. Each student can receive up to \$2,500.

What if my mentor goes on sabbatical?

You must identify a secondary mentor to supervise during the absence, or delay your proposal.

Can I use funds for conference travel?

No. Conference travel is funded through the Magellan Voyager Award (\$500). Magellan Scholar funds are for research-related expenses only.

Do I need IRB approval before applying?

No. IRB/IACUC approval is not required before proposal submission. However, you must obtain approval before beginning relevant research activities.

Can I do research abroad?

Yes. You must comply with the Education Abroad Office requirements, register your travel,

and hold USC-sponsored travel health insurance. All travel must be completed before graduation.

Sources & Further Reading

1. [Magellan Scholar Grant — USC OUR](#)
2. [Magellan Scholar Guidebook \(PDF\)](#)
3. [Proposal Review Rubric \(PDF\)](#)
4. [Applying for the Magellan Scholar Grant](#)
5. [Award Requirements](#)
6. [Using Your Money](#)
7. [For Mentors](#)
8. [USCeRA Submission Guide](#)
9. [CITI Training How-To Guide](#)
10. [Student Research — Office of Research Compliance](#)
11. [Discovery Day Abstracts — Scholar Commons](#)
12. [Helping Guide a Thousand Magellan Voyages \(USC News\)](#)
13. [Magellan Programs Support Undergraduate Research \(USC VPR\)](#)